



Building self-esteem through fun

During the past 11 years, more than 1,000 children have come through the London-based social skills program called Onward and those young people have emerged stronger, happier and more self-aware than when they began. The curriculum is the brainchild of Child and Youth Worker Danielle Aziz who saw that some children were falling through the cracks and set out to find a way to help them.

For children to become successful adults, it is important that they learn more than just the traditional subjects in grade school. They also need to learn how to get along in this world – how to get along with others, how to make friends, and how to understand and work with their emotions in a constructive way.

For many children, these skills come easily but for others, it's a difficult learning curve. When a child has difficulty forging friendships or controlling his or her emotions, the school yard and other social situations can become unhappy and unsettling places. Children know that they don't fit in and it's painful. For their parents, the pain can be just as real and the feeling just as helpless.

Danielle (Gillies) Aziz (*Child and Youth Worker 91*) saw this happening and drew on her education, training and experience to find a way to help them. Her journey to develop the Onward Social Skills Program began during her college years. Her work placements gave her experience as an Educational Assistant and at a residential group home, as well as working alongside a social worker within a school setting.

After graduation, she facilitated groups for self-abusive children and teens before taking on a challenging role with a youth detention centre. When the political landscape changed significantly in Ontario in the mid-1990s, her job was one of many that were cut.

"It was disappointing, but I had been thinking about a future program, researching it, making notes," explains Danielle. "I wanted to help children who were having trouble in school – those with emotional outbursts, who took inappropriate actions, or who just did not make friends easily."

Danielle took training on how to start her own business and Onward

was launched in September 1996. “At the time, many of my colleagues in the Child and Youth field thought I was crazy to try and launch a business like this,” remembers Danielle. “They said that parents would never pay for it, but I was determined. I knew in my heart it had value, but I had to prove it.”

Her initial target was boys and girls who had been diagnosed with ADHD (Attention Deficit Hyperactivity Disorder). She felt that teaching these children social skills and anger management techniques could help them make it through their school day in a better way.

“It worked. We found that once a child knows their place in the class, in the family and in the world, they can begin to respect themselves and believe in themselves a little more each day,” Danielle explains. “Our weekly lessons are reinforced with activities that the children can feel, touch and see. It makes the lessons tangible and real, which is very important for children.”

After year one, Danielle found that the demographic expanded and she set up program streams serving children aged 5 to 14. “We began to see children who were just shy socially; some had behavioural issues like acting out, or trouble getting along with peers – a wide range of things really,” remembers Danielle. “But our program worked for them too. The truth is that improving self-esteem benefits just about any child.”

In addition to hands-on learning each week in class, students leave with a homework sheet. “The homework is not difficult but it reinforces the lessons and lets the parents know what topics we are covering,” explains Danielle.

The curriculum has evolved over the years, based on feedback from children and parents, but the overall goals remain the same. The week-long day camps which run for four weeks each summer also build on

similar themes.

“We are equipping children with skills they need for life: how to get along with others, how to value themselves, and how to better deal with their emotions,” explains Danielle. “All children are unique and we celebrate that. When they start to see their own strengths and become aware of how their actions affect others, they start to make better choices about their behaviour. It is an honour to be part of that process.”



The Onward Social Skills program is a year-round operation in London, Ontario led by founder Danielle Aziz.

Moving Onward: making learning fun



It takes a team approach to deliver the Onward program to the busy groups of school age children. Founder Danielle Aziz (above at right) has seven assistants who help her with the program and very often, her staff members also have Fanshawe connections.

For example, Amie Langrell (at centre) just completed her first year at Fanshawe enrolled in the Child and Youth Worker (C&YW) program. Amie has been working with the Onward program since she was a teen herself and is now studying towards a career in the field. Steph Hatcher (above left) worked on a four-month placement while attending her third year within the C&YW program.

The key to success at Onward is delivering the learning in a fun and creative way. Each session has a theme and a series of hands-on activities, such as poems, role-play, stories or games that drive home the message.

“We show children ways to take responsibility for their lives and their actions,” explains Danielle. “We help them recognize their strengths and their potential. Children learn to understand their emotions better and deal with them in an empowering, assertive way. They make friends within the program and back at school. These are all important skills for life.”

To get more information about Onward and its programs, visit www.onwardsun.com.